Web Designer's Toolkit: Free Resources for My Students

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A gift for you

Every link in this toolkit is free, and each one saves you hours of work on real websites. You learned HTML, CSS, JavaScript and Bootstrap the hard way, by writing everything yourself. Now use these tools to build faster, and to make your websites look professional.

How to use it:

1. Bookmark this document and keep it open when you start a new website.
2. Pick one tool from a section, try it in a small test page first, then add it to your project.
3. Always read the tool's "Getting Started" or "Docs" page. Most tools need only one `<link>` or `<script>` line.
4. Never just copy code. Understand it, change it, and make it yours.

Templates and design inspiration

Don't start from a blank page. Download a free template, study how it is built, then change it into your own website.

Resource	What it does	Use it when
Colorlib	Hundreds of free HTML/CSS/Bootstrap website templates	You need a complete website to start from
ThemeWagon	Free Bootstrap and HTML templates, sorted by category	You want a modern template for a business, shop or portfolio
HTML5 UP	Beautiful, fully responsive free templates	You want a clean portfolio or landing page
Start Bootstrap	Free Bootstrap themes and templates	You want to see how Bootstrap is used in real pages

Resource	What it does	Use it when
CodePen	Online editor with millions of small HTML/CSS/JS demos	You need ideas for a button, card, navbar, loader or animation
Uiverse	Free ready-made buttons, cards, loaders, toggles, inputs	You want one stylish element, copy-paste ready
Dribbble	Designs by professional designers	You need inspiration for layout and colors
Behance	Full website and app design case studies	You want to see a complete design idea

Tip: on CodePen, search for exactly what you need, e.g. "css card hover" or "responsive navbar".

Contact forms without a backend

An HTML form cannot send email on its own. These services receive your form's data and send it to your email inbox, with no PHP or server needed.

Resource	What it does	How it works
Web3Forms	Sends contact form submissions to your email	Get a free access key with your email, add it as a hidden input, set the form `action` to their URL
Formspree	Same idea, with a dashboard of all messages	Create a form on the site, paste its URL in your form's `action`
EmailJS	Sends email straight from JavaScript	Connect your Gmail, then call one JS function on submit

Tip: test your form once with your own email before you show it to anyone.

Sliders, animations and popups

These small libraries make a website feel alive. Add one with a CDN link, then follow its example code.

Resource	What it does	Good for
Owl Carousel	Touch-friendly sliders (needs jQuery)	Testimonials, logo sliders, product sliders
Swiper	Modern slider with no jQuery needed	Hero banners, image galleries, mobile-style swiping
WOW.js	Starts an animation when you scroll to a section	Sections that appear as the user scrolls down
Animate.css	Ready-made CSS animations: fade, bounce, zoom, slide	Use alone, or together with WOW.js
AOS	"Animate On Scroll" with simple `data-aos` attributes	Same as WOW.js, easier to set up
SweetAlert2	Beautiful popup boxes instead of the plain `alert()`	Form success messages, delete confirmations
Typed.js	Typing text effect	A hero heading like "I am a Web Designer..."
Lottie	Lightweight animated illustrations	Animated icons, loaders, hero images

Tip: don't put animation on everything. One or two effects per page look professional; ten look messy.

Icons and fonts

Good icons and fonts are the fastest way to make a page look professional.

Resource	What it does
Font Awesome	The most popular icon library: social media, shopping, arrows and more
Bootstrap Icons	2,000+ free icons that match Bootstrap's style
Remix Icon	Clean, modern open-source icons
Iconify	Search icons from many libraries in one place

Resource	What it does
Google Fonts	Hundreds of free fonts, added with one `<link>` line
Fontjoy	Suggests font pairs that look good together

Tip: use at most two fonts on one website, one for headings and one for body text.

Free images and illustrations

Never take random images from Google Images; many are copyrighted. These sites give you images you are allowed to use for free.

Resource	What it does
Unsplash	High-quality free photos
Pexels	Free photos and short videos, great for hero backgrounds
Pixabay	Free photos, illustrations and vectors
unDraw	Free illustrations; you can change their color to match your website
Storyset	Free illustrations, some of them animated
Picsum Photos	Placeholder images by URL while you build, e.g. `https://picsum.photos/400/250`
TinyPNG	Makes your images smaller so the website loads faster

Colors and CSS generators

These tools write tricky CSS for you. Choose the look you want, then copy the generated code.

Resource	What it does
Coolors	Generates color palettes; press the spacebar for a new one
Color Hunt	Ready-made, hand-picked color palettes
CSS Gradient	Builds gradient backgrounds and gives you the CSS
uiGradients	A collection of beautiful ready gradients
Get Waves	Wave-shaped section dividers (SVG)
Haikei	Blob, wave and layered background shapes
CSS Box Shadow Generator	Soft, modern shadows for cards and buttons
Clippy	Makes shapes with `clip-path` (triangles, slants, hexagons)
Neumorphism.io	Soft 3D "neumorphic" button and card styles

Keep learning and practicing

The course will end, but practice should not. Spend 30 minutes a day on these and you will keep getting better.

Resource	What it does
MDN Web Docs	The most trusted reference for HTML, CSS and JavaScript
W3Schools	Simple tutorials with a "Try it Yourself" editor
Flexbox Froggy	A game that teaches Flexbox
Grid Garden	A game that teaches CSS Grid
CSS-Tricks Flexbox Guide	The famous one-page Flexbox cheat sheet
JavaScript.info	JavaScript explained step by step, from basics to advanced
freeCodeCamp	Free courses and certificates in web development

Resource	What it does
Frontend Mentor	Real website designs to build, the best practice for your portfolio

Publish your website for free

A website on your laptop is a file; a website with a link is a portfolio. Put every project online and share the link in your CV.

Resource	What it does	Difficulty
Netlify Drop	Drag your website folder onto the page and get a live link	Easiest
GitHub Pages	Free hosting straight from your GitHub repository	Easy, and your code is on GitHub too
Vercel	Fast hosting, connects to GitHub	Easy
GitHub	Keeps all your code and projects online	Every developer needs an account

Tip: your homepage file must be named `index.html`, or the hosting site will not find it.

VS Code extensions and AI helpers

The right editor setup and good AI habits make you faster without making you lazy.

Tool	What it does
VS Code	The free code editor most web developers use
Live Server	Refreshes the browser by itself every time you save
Prettier	Formats your code neatly with one shortcut
Auto Rename Tag	Change an opening tag and the closing tag changes too

Tool	What it does
ChatGPT / Claude	Explain code, find bugs, generate sample data and small sections
GitHub Copilot	Suggests code while you type inside VS Code

Good AI habits:

- Ask AI to explain code, not only to write it.
- Name the version in your prompt, e.g. "Bootstrap 6", so you get code that works.
- Read every line AI gives you. If you can't explain it, don't use it.
- Save your best prompts; a good prompt is a skill too.